

China Steel - Channel checker

10-day China steel output +3% vs previous; Iron ore FOB price remains weaker vs pre-war as freight rates tick up



10-day China steel output 996Mt annualised, +3% vs previous: The latest China daily crude steel output (10 days to 10 Jul) is tracking at a run rate of 996Mt annualised. This is +3% vs the previous 10 days (to 30 Jun) and +1% YoY. Trailing 30-day steel production is -2% vs the previous 30-day period, -1% YoY. Despite an edge higher vs the previous 10-day print, the print remains at the bottom end of the historical seasonal range. JPM's China economists note that the latest China economic data suggest weak fixed asset investments ("FAI") ([link](#)), which fell 10.0%ooya in June and 5.7% ytd and full-year real GDP forecast has been lowered to 4.6%/y from 4.7%, reflecting weaker domestic demand and a tougher external environment. Together with the economic data, our interpretation is that China's steel production in 2026 may now already have peaked (1,033Mt annualised, 10 May) and the slowdown trend for H2 may have commenced.

New rounds of escalation in the Middle East in the past two weeks has sent the latest reported bulk shipping rates up again – the Australia to China shipping rate increased by 9% (+\$1/t) WoW. The freight rate-adjusted FOB iron ore price remains lower vs pre-Iran war and YTD. The Australian FOB iron ore price is -6% YTD and -1% vs end-Feb at \$86/t and Brazilian FOB iron ore price -14% YTD and -9% vs end-Feb at \$66/t. In the production reporting this week, both BHP and RIO reported slightly weaker (~\$1/t) iron ore realised pricing vs JPMe ([link](#) / [link](#)).

Among EMEA Metals & Mining iron ore exposed equities, we are **Neutral on Rio Tinto and BHP's London listing**, our colleague Lyndon Fagan is OW BHP's Primary Australia listing and is OW Rio Tinto Ltd. **With greater exposure to iron ore bulk shipping rates in Brazil and South Africa, we see Anglo American and Kumba Iron Ore as more susceptible to margin pressure.** In our published preview last week ([link](#)), we placed **Anglo American on Negative Catalyst Watch** into Q2'26 production results as we expect disappointing Iron Ore price realisations, weak Diamonds H1 EBITDA and group cost inflation. We closed our UW on **Kumba and upgraded to Neutral** following a ~30% share price pullback since February.

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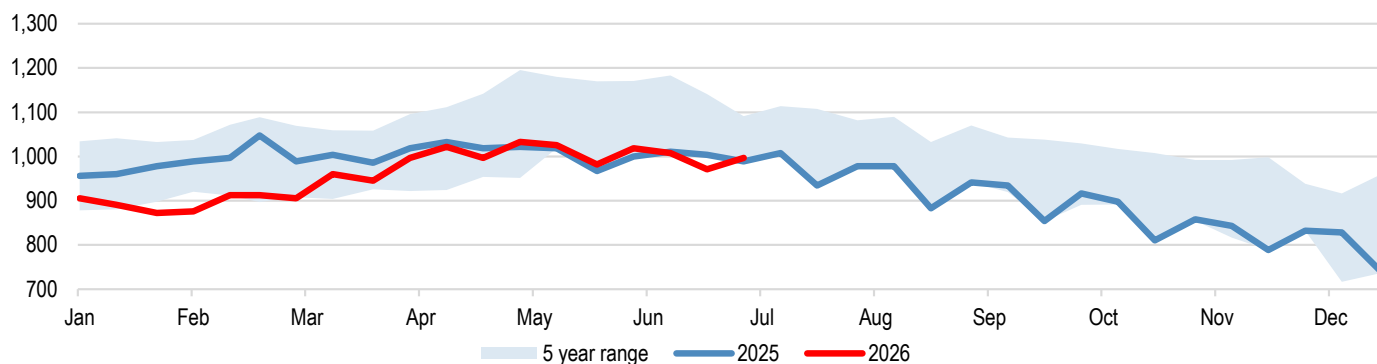
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Figure 1: Total China steel output 996Mt annualised run rate: daily CISA steel output for 10-days ended 10 Jul: +3% vs previous (+1% YoY), in line with seasonal trend

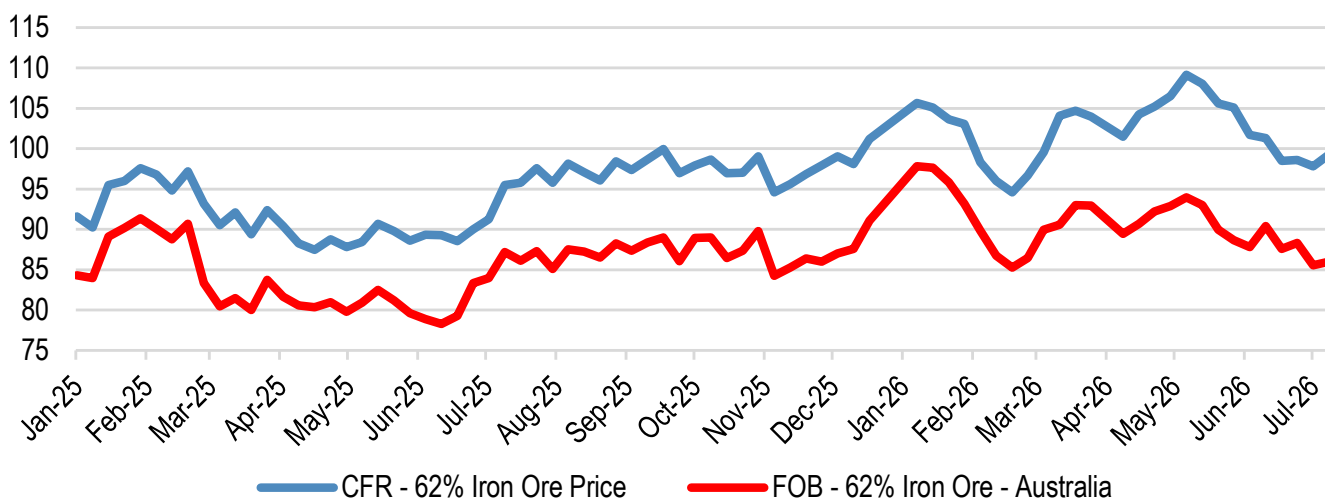
Mtpa (annualised)



Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, CISA, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

Figure 2: FOB iron ore price from Australia to China at ~\$86/t, -1% vs end-Feb and -\$5/t YTD

LHS: Iron ore price \$/mt; RHS: Shipping cost \$/mt

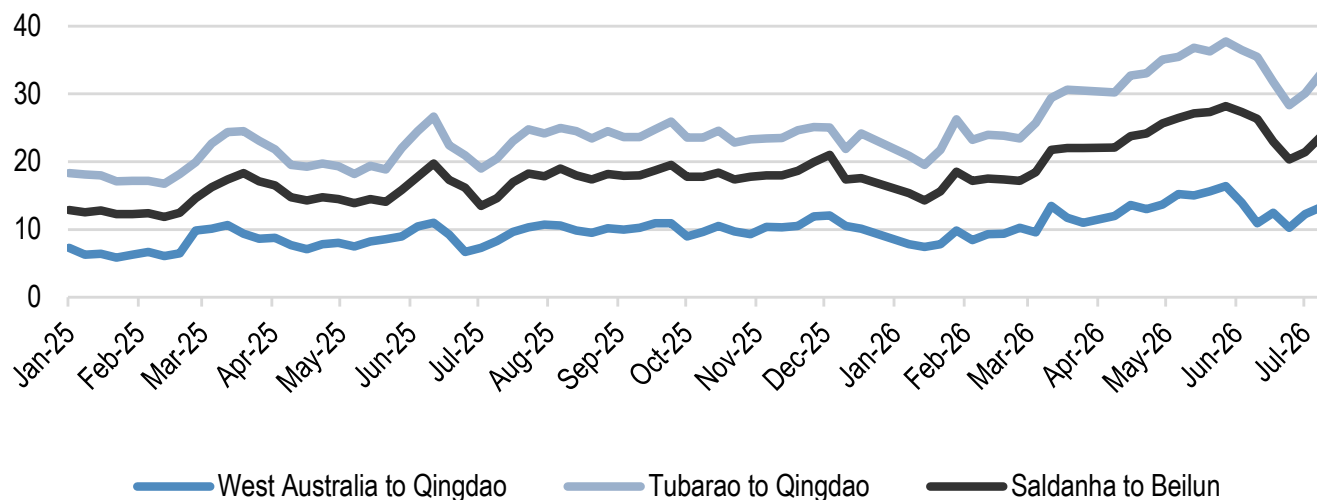


FOB 62% Iron Ore price calculated as CFR 62% Iron Ore price less West Australia to Qingdao bulk shipping costs.

Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

Figure 3: Iron ore bulk shipping costs from Australia, Brazil and South Africa to China ticked up in the past week due to latest escalation in the Middle East

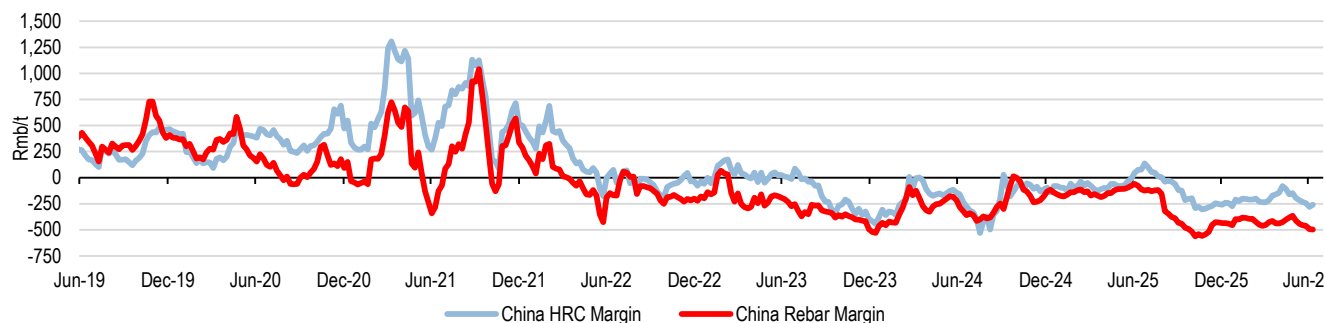
LHS: Iron ore price \$/mt; RHS: Shipping cost \$/mt



FOB 62% Iron Ore price calculated as CFR 62% Iron Ore price less West Australia to Qingdao bulk shipping costs.
Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

Figure 4: China steel mill margins extend losses in the past few weeks on higher coking coal prices

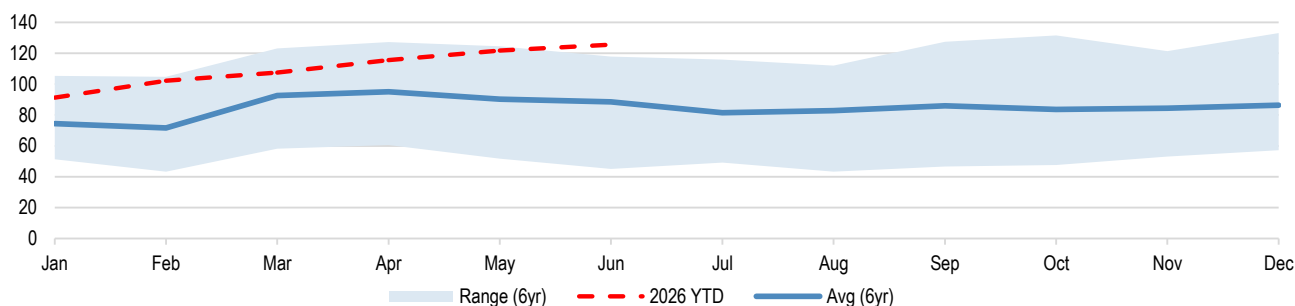
RMB/t



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P., J.P. Morgan estimates.

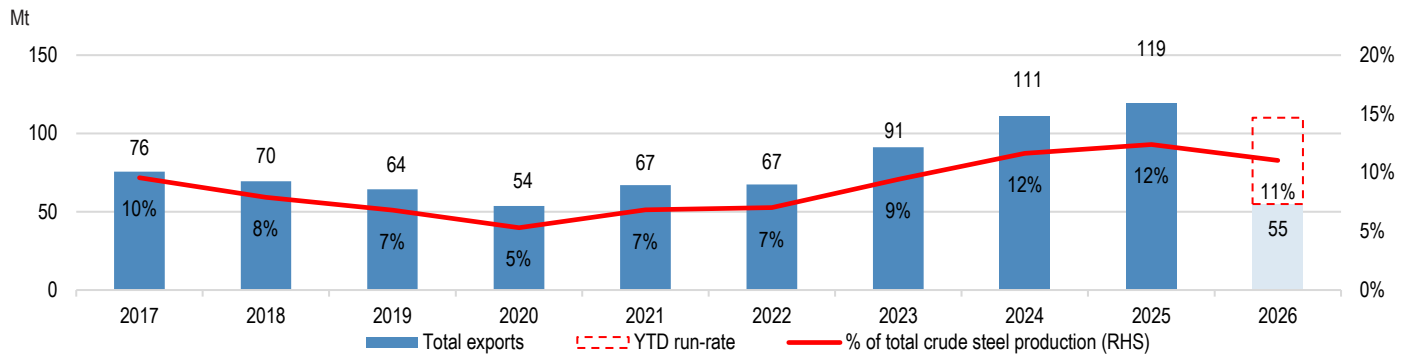
Figure 5: Total China Steel exports (seasonality): Jun'26 export run-rate of 126Mtpa at top end of historical average

Mtpa exports (annualised)



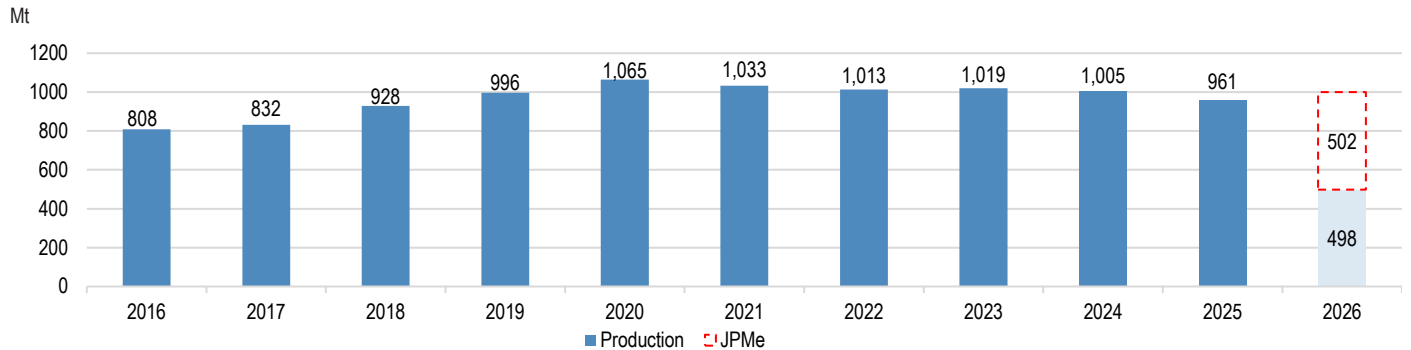
Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

Figure 6: 6M'2026 China steel exports at 55Mt, tracking at ~ 11% of total output



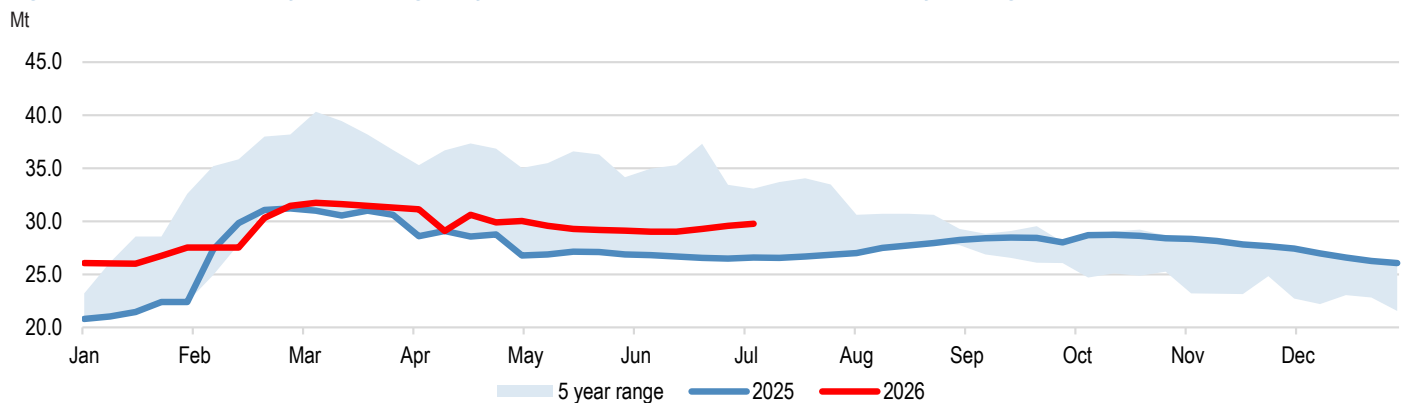
Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

Figure 7: Official NBS China steel output (annualised) – we estimate 2026 China steel production at ~1,000Mt



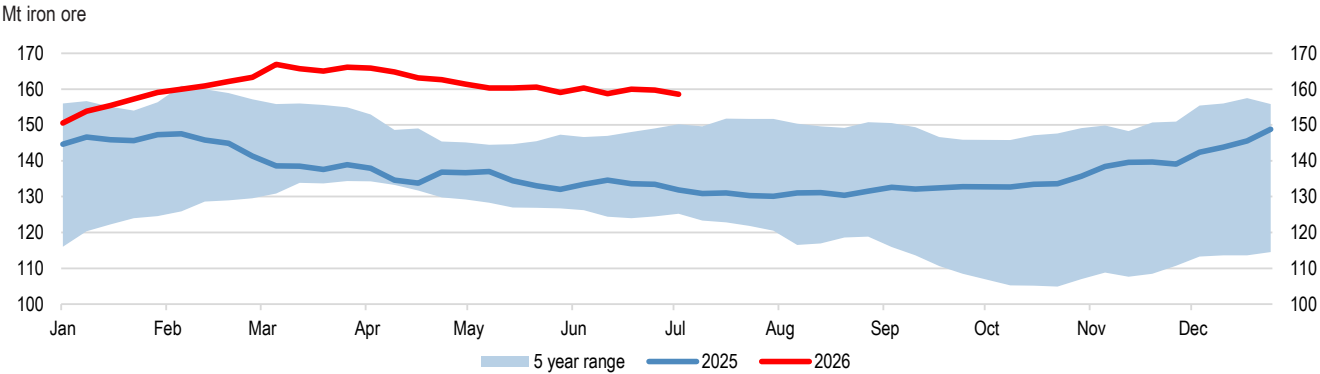
Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, NBS, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

Figure 8: China steel inventory week ending 9 July, +1% WoW and +12% YoY; total steel inventory tracking in line with seasonal level



Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

Figure 9: Iron Ore inventory held at ports in China at ~160Mt, tracking at historical high but 7Mt down since peak inventory in March



Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

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